minister often referred to these payments in his speeches. As he told a Kannauj audience, ‘This money is yours, it is your right, you own it. Not even Rs 2 from this money can be taken away by any government. And this won’t be paid once. It will be paid thrice a year to you.’[13]

Similarly, a few months earlier, in Telangana, over 5.7 million farmers received two payments of ₹4,000 for each acre of land they cultivated per crop season as part of the Telangana Rashtra Samithi (TRS)-led state government’s Rythu Bandhu (Farmer’s Friend) Scheme. The last of these instalments of ₹4,000 was made in October 2018 through DBTs, just a month before the Telangana state election in November 2018, after due permission from the ECI. This DBT, until then the largest such pre-election cash transfer in India, was said to have played a major factor in shoring up political support for the TRS and its return to power.[14] The Modi government followed a similar playbook with PM-Kisan and other schemes in 2019.

Now, all governments since Independence have spent money on development. The large numbers of Congress-era schemes that were renamed under the Modi regime is a case in point. At one stage, the Congress listed almost three dozen such schemes on its website—the implication being that the Modi government had somehow stolen its ideas and was taking unfair advantage of them by rebranding them.[15] Several scholars have written about the Modi government’s mid-term pivot to welfare and redistributive policies with these schemes. Their diagnoses have ranged from the rise of a new kind of welfare populism to pointing to a strategy of personally linking the prime minister’s imagery with that of these schemes as a benefactor of the poor, practising what has been called the politics of ‘vishwas’.[16] Yamini Aiyar, for example, has argued that ‘more than the policies themselves, what distinguished Modi’s approach to welfare was the presentation and handling of them in ways that enhanced the Modi persona. Policies that the government said had priority had the initials PM (for ‘Prime Minister’) added as a prefix before their names, suggesting the idea of a connection between Modi himself and the beneficiaries.’[17]